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What is the role of needs analysis in agile projects for Business Analysis?

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Alicia Zaklan

Agile Leader | Strategic Advisor | Transformation Architect | Culture Designer | Organizational Systems Expert |...

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Tanya Gupta

Author of 'Discovering The Silver Bullet' | AVP @ Barclays | LinkedIn Top Voice | Certified Scrum Master | Grace Hopper...

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1 Agile principles and needs analysis

Agile projects follow a set of principles that emphasize customer satisfaction, early and frequent delivery, working software, collaboration, responsiveness, and self-organizing teams. These principles imply that needs analysis in agile projects is not a one-time activity, but a continuous and dynamic process that evolves along with the project. Needs analysis in agile projects aims to deliver value to the customer and the business by aligning the project vision, goals, and outcomes with the customer needs, expectations, and feedback.

Samyuktha G [Follow](#)

Business Technology Analyst @ Deloitte | Agile, Testing

In Agile projects, needs analysis is crucial for aligning product development with stakeholder requirements. It involves continuous collaboration and adaptation, ensuring that the delivered product meets evolving needs. By identifying priorities, such as through techniques like MoSCoW prioritization, and involving stakeholders throughout the process, teams can focus on delivering the most valuable features. For example, in software development, needs analysis might...

13

Susan Cave [Follow](#)

Senior Business Analyst

A *good* BA can add much to any project, bringing critical requirements analysis and pragmatic solution definition to complex end to end processes which cross multiple business areas and/or systems. Understanding the complete E2E process is, in my opinion, essential, but is often difficult (and impractical) for business & product orientated teams.

Agile is an amazing tool but for some project types it can introduce its own risks. Wat...

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with business goals and deliver maximum value early in the development cycle. This iterative process helps in adapting to changing requirements and promotes continuous improvement throughout the project lifecycle. [...see more](#)

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Nwezi Kingsley [Follow](#)

Technical Business Analyst | Product Manager | Product Owner | API Management | Solution A...

Traditionally BAs were meant to function in a Waterfall Software development model. In Agile, BAs has to work hand in hand with the Product Owner to deliver the project in iterations. To deliver good value in an agile setting the BA can also double up as a Product owner to ensure requirements are not lost or misrepresented when developing the Product backlog [...see more](#)

3

Yulia Pshevlotskaya, CBAP [Follow](#)

Business Analyst @Gurtam | IIBA Volunteer & Mentor

In the Business Analysis Core Concept Model (BABOK), 'needs' represents one of the six fundamental elements (stakeholders, change, solution, context, value). Regardless of the project environment, be it agile or waterfall, the primary and immediate task for a business analyst is to elicit the actual needs of stakeholders. And It's crucial to acknowledge that these needs can evolve over time. Therefore, in an agile setting, the business analyst plays a proactive r...[see more](#)

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2 Needs analysis techniques for agile projects

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show different touchpoints and channels. Lastly, prototypes are mock-ups or simulations of the software that allow users and stakeholders to provide feedback and insights for improvement.

Ima Ntia [Follow](#)

Business Systems Analysis | Change Management | Process Improvements | Business Process ...

I have seen how needs analysis plays a huge part in understanding stakeholder requirements and expectations, typically guiding the creation of meaningful user stories. This usually allows for the development of effective test cases to evaluate the alignment of the work completed with the defined requirements. Transparently sharing the user story acceptance criteria and test results with the team helps with open communication, efficient testing, user feedback, and co...see more

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Moyosore Salawu [Follow](#)

♦ **CBAP Certified Senior Business Analyst** ♦ **10+ Years' Analysis Experience** ~ Degree in...

In my experience in the context of agile projects, needs analysis performed by a BA aims to gain a thorough comprehension of stakeholder requirements. This process aids in the effective prioritizations of needs and shapes the creation of our user stories. It fosters a collaborative environment, ensuring requirements are accurately validated and verified. Furthermore, this analysis serves as a catalyst for perpetual enhancement throughout the duration of the...see more

5

Yulia Pshevlotskaya, CBAP [Follow](#)

Business Analyst @Gurtam | IIBA Volunteer & Mentor

(edited)

The following techniques can be applied for conducting needs analysis in agile projects:

- Observation: Valuable insights can be gained by observing or shadowing users as they interact with the product or perform their tasks and not share some details during the interview for example because they seem for them obvious. ...see more

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they have been around forever. Ever seen how new car models were built with clay in the 50s/60s to evaluate and test new ideas? The difference is in HOW these techniques are used in an Agile project - more frequently, iteratively. [...see more](#)

Evguenia Fonova [Follow](#)

Lean Enthusiast | Agile | Scrum Master | Continuous Improvement | Business Analyst | Data An...

In agile projects, needs analysis goes beyond traditional documentation. Business Analysts leverage techniques that promote flexibility and continuous improvement. User stories, concise descriptions of functionalities from the user's perspective, capture the essence of a need. Regular stakeholder interviews and workshops foster open communication, ensuring alignment with evolving needs. User Acceptance Testing (UAT) sessions provide valuable user feedback...[see more](#)

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3 Needs analysis roles and responsibilities for agile projects

In agile projects, the role of the business analyst is not limited to conducting needs analysis, but also involves facilitating collaboration, communication, and coordination among the team and the customer. The business analyst also helps define and refine the project scope, vision, and goals, manage the backlog and the requirements, and support the testing and delivery of the software. The business analyst works closely with the product owner, who is responsible for representing the customer's voice, defining the product vision and value proposition, prioritizing and accepting the user stories, and providing feedback and direction to the team. The business analyst also collaborates with the developers, testers, designers, and other team members who are responsible for creating, testing, and delivering the software.

Alicia Zaklan [Follow](#)

Agile Leader | Strategic Advisor | Transformation Architect | Culture Designer | Organizational ...

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engagement, responsive to the product owner, who should be responsive to making st...see more

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Replies from Brent Gamble and more: Agree ..continual collaboration with business stakeholders is important .and timely responsiveness

Kirsti Ferrari [Follow](#)

Product Owner / Lead Business Analyst - Salesforce

As a Senior Business Analyst who has been in a large number of agile teams I would say the common success factor for me is where I am able to be the 'swiss army knife' for the team members whilst being the right hand of the product owner. What makes us great as analysts makes us great at clearing the way, supporting team members in their thinking, building relationships with stakeholders to aid in clarification and just in general being flexible t...see more

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Zahra Soleimani Heydari [Follow](#)

"International Senior Business and Systems Analyst | Expertise in Global Software Engineering, ...

As a business analyst who is not only conducting needs analysis, but also, I responsible facilitating collaboration, communication, and coordination among the team and the customer. What I mean is that the business analysts have a variety number of responsible such as define the scope of the project, collect the requirements, identify the stakeholders, manage the backlog and support the testing and delivery of the software. We work with costumers who givi...see more

7

Anton Oosthuizen PMP, ACP, PBA, CSPO, AvMP [Follow](#)

Senior Business Analyst / Project Manager / Airport Operations at Self-Employed.

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regardless if it works or not. The BA role has ALWAYS included facilitation and commun...see more

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Les Sherlock Hewkin [Follow](#)

Experienced Business Analyst

I've worked in a few different organisations who use Agile methods. I've found that the ones that deliver are those that make use of a BA'S talents. They are a vital bridge between the business and the technical team members. Many years ago, as a techy I've fallen into the trap of thinking I understood the requirements without double checking. BA'S shouldn't be sidelined in Agile teams. ...see more

2

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4 Needs analysis challenges and pitfalls for agile projects

Needs analysis in agile projects can face some challenges and pitfalls that can affect the quality and success of the project. For instance, the customer's needs may be unclear or changing due to changing market conditions, user feedback, or business priorities. This could lead to confusion, delays, rework, or scope creep in the project. To prevent this, the business analyst and product owner should collaborate to clarify, validate, and prioritize the needs and communicate them clearly and consistently to the team and customer. Additionally, communication is key to ensure that the needs are understood, agreed upon, and met. However, communication can be inadequate or ineffective due to lack of time, tools, or skills. To counter this issue, the business analyst and product owner should use diverse communication methods and channels such as face-to-face meetings, online tools, documentation, and feedback loops. Moreover, feedback is essential to validate and improve the needs and software in agile projects. But feedback can be insufficient or irrelevant due to lack of involvement or interest of users and stakeholders. To avoid this problem, the business analyst and product owner should identify and engage the right users and stakeholders as well as solicit and collect feedback regularly and systematically.

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I think it is important to consult a range of users and stakeholders to ensure the correct information is gathered from the start and allow requirements to be as accurate as possible as well as ensuring the solution is suitable for all. ... [...see more](#)

6

Olympe Govi CSPO, CSM [Follow](#)

Business Analyst / Scrum Master

Being able to oversee the scope of the project is key to success. Effective project management hinges on a comprehensive understanding of its needs analysis. Through my experiences, I've learned to prioritize the delight of end users, which led me to choose business process reengineering over business expansion. I've discovered that aligning with stakeholders involves more than meeting their wants; it requires a discerning focus on their genuine needs. T...see more

1

Anton Oosthuizen PMP, ACP, PBA, CSPO, AvMP [Follow](#)

Senior Business Analyst / Project Manager / Airport Operations at Self-Employed.

"Challenges" such as clarify and change have ALWAYS been a reality. It is not an Agile phenomenon. And it has ALWAYS been the responsibility of a good BA to make sure needs meet the minimum standards to be considered good. The only thing that leads to confusion is the fact that this article thinks that any of these challenges are new and/or unique to agile proj...see more

1

Rafaela D. [Follow](#)

Business Analyst | Requirements | Digital Agricultural Product Specialist | Technical Writer

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habilidades, decisiones, etapas, e equipos variadas....

...see more

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Ghaith Aljamal [Follow](#)

Business Analyst | Agile | Product Owner

Although there are a lot of challenges for the needs analysis in agile but most of these challenges will lead to a successful project unlike using traditional methodologies where these challenges will not be discovered until the last phases of the project life cycle and leads into huge issues or project failure

...

...see more

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5 Needs analysis benefits and outcomes for agile projects

Needs analysis in agile projects can bring many benefits and outcomes for the business analysis and the project. For example, increased customer satisfaction is achieved as software meets or exceeds customer needs, expectations, and feedback. This also enhances the reputation and credibility of the business. Additionally, improved quality and performance is achieved as the software is designed, developed, and tested according to the needs and requirements of the user and the stakeholder. Finally, enhanced collaboration and innovation is fostered as ideas, feedback, and solutions are shared, discussed, and implemented in an iterative, adaptive, and flexible way. Ultimately, needs analysis in agile projects can create a positive and productive working environment.

Anton Oosthuizen PMP, ACP, PBA, CSPO, AvMP [Follow](#)

Senior Business Analyst / Project Manager / Airport Operations at Self-Employed.

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projects other than Agile not also create a positive and productive environment?

...see more

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Evguenia Fonova [Follow](#)

Lean Enthusiast | Agile | Scrum Master | Continuous Improvement | Business Analyst | Data An...

In agile projects, needs analysis isn't just about gathering requirements; it's a cornerstone for delivering high-value products. By continuously focusing on stakeholder needs throughout the project lifecycle, Business Analysts ensure the features developed are truly relevant and solve real problems. This ongoing analysis empowers teams to adapt to changing priorities or market shifts. Regular communication and collaboration with stakeholders, facilitated by needs...see more

1

Jayalakshmi Paladugu [Follow](#)

Global Services Practice Leader - AWS | Premier Consulting Partner* & Distribution

1. Needs analysis helps identify and prioritize the most critical requirements based on stakeholder needs and business objectives.
2. Emphasize iterative development and continuous improvement and are aligned with the broader strategic goals of the organization.
3. Open communication and shared understanding of project requirements, agile team...see more

Jennifer B. [Follow](#)

Senior Business Systems Analyst | QA | PO

Needs analysis provides the capability for the stakeholders and project team to align and understand the reasons for the project. This process contributes to the understanding of business requirements and project scope, and provides a foundation for the project team to create detailed user stories for the approved features, establish the definition of Acceptance Criteria and provide useful information to the development team. The QA team will als...see more

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Sphoorthy P. [Follow](#)

Product Owner @ Amadeus | SAFe 5 POPM® CBAP® CISA® PSM® AZ-900® |

Needs change or evolve over time so should projects vision and scope. At the end project's output should deliver value to customer. Hence need have to be assessed on continuous basis

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6 Here's what else to consider

This is a space to share examples, stories, or insights that don't fit into any of the previous sections. What else would you like to add?

Tanya Gupta [Follow](#)

Author of 'Discovering The Silver Bullet' | AVP @ Barclays | LinkedIn Top Voice | Certified Scrum...

In the Agile methodology, needs analysis is not a one-time event but rather an ongoing and collaborative process. Business analysts (BAs) work closely with stakeholders, development teams, and other project participants to ensure the project delivers the right solutions to address identified needs. The iterative nature of Agile provides flexibility and responsiveness to changing business needs, making the role of needs analysis even more crucial in delivering value...see more

74



Steve Smith replied: Has anyone ever stopped to consider that the words "Agile" and "methodology" are kinda antonyms and thus form an oxymoron?

Steven W. [Follow](#)

Technical Project Manager @ RHI Magnesita | Project Management

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approach allows for continuous refinement and improvement throughout the project it...see more

5

Alok Chadha, AIII, CIP, CSM, PMP [Follow](#)

"Product Management & Agile InsureTech Enthusiast with a Passion for Real Estate."

In agile projects, needs analysis is essential for understanding stakeholder needs, defining and prioritizing requirements, aligning with business goals, facilitating communication, managing risks, and planning iterations. It ensures the development team delivers valuable, incremental improvements and adapts efficiently to changes.

...see more

5

Aparna Debnath [Follow](#)

Assistant Vice President at Barclays | Ex-JP Morgan

Analysis makes up 50% of the work that a business analyst does. It is that crucial and critical for a BA.

Needs analysis in agile projects is crucial for aligning development with stakeholder needs. It involves continuous requirements gathering, refining the product backlog, and prioritiz...see more

4

Palkesh Bhura [Follow](#)

Certified Business Analyst | Certified Agile Business Analyst | PSM trained | PSPO trained | ECB...

Need analysis is most important so that you can make sure requirement is SMART, need analysis is required to checking the feasibility of the requirements, prototyping , impact analysis and risk analysis. Need analysis helps to understand the future state so that you can perform the gap analysis between current state and future state.

...see more

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